

Skills Summary

Where Is the Shape? Position Words on a Shelf

Use this reference while completing your worksheet or when studying.

A position word tells *where* something is, not what it looks like. On a numbered shelf you can always check a position word with numbers: shelves are counted from the bottom up, and spots are counted from the left. Point at both shapes, read their numbers, then compare.

Skill 1 — Above and below

Rule: Shelf 1 is the bottom shelf. The **bigger** shelf number is **higher up**. So if the first shape's shelf number is bigger, it is *above*; if it is smaller, it is *below*.

Example: A ball is on shelf 4. A book is on shelf 2. Is the ball above or below the book?

Step 1. The question is about high and low, so look at the shelf numbers and compare them.

Step 2. The ball is 4 and the book is 2. Four is more than two.

$4 > 2$ so the ball is **above** the book.

Try it: A hat is on shelf 1. A cup is on shelf 3. Compare the two shelf numbers with $<$ or $>$.

check: 1 > 3 — the hat is below

Skill 2 — Left and right

Rule: Spot 1 is farthest left. The **bigger** spot number is farther **right**. Shelf numbers do not help here, and spot numbers do not tell you anything about high and low.

Example: A mug is in spot 2. A plate is in spot 5. Is the mug to the left or the right of the plate?

Step 1. The question is about left and right, so this time look at the spot numbers.

Step 2. The mug is 2 and the plate is 5. Two is less than five.

$2 < 5$ so the mug is to the **left** of the plate.

Try it: A bag is in spot 6. A boot is in spot 3. Compare the two spot numbers with $<$ or $>$.

check: 6 > 3 — the bag is to the right

Skill 3 — Putting shapes in order

Rule: To line shapes up, write their position numbers in order. *Bottom to top* and *left to right* both go smallest first. *Top to bottom* and *right to left* both go biggest first.

Example: Three shapes are on shelves 3, 1 and 2. Put them in order from the bottom shelf to the top shelf.

Step 1. Bottom to top means lowest shelf first, so the smallest number leads.

Step 2. The numbers are 3, 1 and 2. Counting order puts 1 first, then 2, then 3.

1, 2, 3

Try it: Three shapes are in spots 2, 4 and 1. Put the spot numbers in order from right to left.

check: 4, 2, 1

Skill 4 — Telling what is between

Rule: A shape is *between* two others when its position number lands in the **middle** once all three numbers are put in order. Both neighbours must be on the same shelf, or “between” does not apply.

Example: On one shelf, a shape sits in spot 4, another in spot 1, and a third in spot 2. Which one is between the other two?

Step 1. “Between” is about the middle, so put all three spot numbers in order first and then look at the one in the middle.

Step 2. The numbers 4, 1 and 2 in counting order are 1, then 2, then 4, and 2 is the middle one.

1, 2, 4 so the shape in spot 2 is **between** the other two.

Try it: On one shelf, shapes sit in spots 5, 2 and 3. Put the numbers in order, then say which spot is in the middle.

check: 5, 3, 2 — spot 3 is between

(!) Watch out: Answer in the order the question asks. If it says “the oval and the hexagon,” write the oval’s number first — swapping them flips $<$ and $>$ and turns *below* into *above*. And a shape can be above one shape and below another at the same time, so always name which shape you are comparing it with.